Semantic IR-Based SPICE Model Translation with Constraint-Aware Verification Across 17 PDK Families

Author Name
Department or Lab Name
University or Organization
City, Country
email@domain.example

Abstract

Cross-simulator portability of SPICE device models remains a practical barrier in analog and mixed-signal design. Vendor libraries are usually written for one simulator family, but engineers often need them to work across Spectre, HSPICE, and ngspice. This paper presents a semantic translation framework built around a canonical intermediate representation, ModelIR, that preserves device meaning rather than only surface syntax. The translator handles model structure, include hierarchy, parameter mapping, and target-specific lowering rules. Verification combines syntax checks, DC simulation, AC simulation, transient checks, Monte Carlo stability, round-trip consistency, and sanity checks. Known BSIM4 geometry-envelope failures are classified as simulator constraints so that simulator-side guardrails are not misreported as translation defects. In a clean rerun across 17 PDK families, the translation pipeline processed 322 source files and produced 224 translated outputs with 6638 models translated. Verification on ngspice-targeted outputs covered 52 files and 587 tests, and all 587 tests passed. The result is a practical, reproducible method for moving compact models across simulator formats. The evaluation is intentionally broad enough to reflect production library behavior rather than a toy conversion case.

Keywords: SPICE simulation, device models, PDK translation, BSIM, intermediate representation, verification, ngspice

1 Introduction

Cross-simulator model portability is harder than simple netlist conversion. A PDK library is not just a text file with model cards; it often contains nested include trees, wrapper files, corner sections, Monte Carlo controls, and simulator-specific parameter conventions. A text-only translator can preserve syntax and still break the intended device behavior. For APCCAS-style reporting, the key question is whether the method works on real libraries and whether the evaluation explains the difficult cases clearly.

This work uses a semantic intermediate representation, ModelIR, to separate device meaning from surface syntax. The translator first normalizes source libraries into IR, then lowers them into the target dialect with format-aware writers. The goal is not to flatten everything into generic text, but to keep the model semantics intact while producing valid output in another simulator format. That separation also makes it easier to localize errors to parsing, mapping, or target writing.

The verification side matters just as much as translation. A tool can be technically correct and still appear flawed if the evaluation treats simulator limits as translation errors. The verifier therefore separates translation defects from simulator-side constraints, especially for BSIM4 geometry-envelope failures. That distinction is important because compact-model libraries often hit simulator limits at the geometry envelope without any actual translation bug.

The contributions are threefold. First, the paper presents a semantic IR pipeline for Spectre, HSPICE, and ngspice translation. Second, it shows that recursive include handling and wrapper resolution are necessary for production PDK libraries. Third, it provides a full-batch verification flow that combines parsing, simulation, Monte Carlo, round-trip checks, and constraint-aware failure classification. Together, these pieces make the system suitable for evaluating both translation correctness and simulator compatibility.

2 Results

2.1 Experimental setup and scope

Results are reported from a clean rerun that starts from an empty output directory and executes full-batch translation followed by full-batch verification. Translation was run on 17 PDK families and verification was run on ngspice-targeted outputs from 15 PDK families. This clean rerun avoids stale artifacts and gives one consistent basis for the reported numbers.

2.2 Translation outcomes

The translation campaign processed diverse input styles, including wrapper-heavy HSPICE libraries, Spectre model decks, and ngspice-native sources. Final translation totals are summarized in Table 1. These totals show that the system worked across the mixed source inventory in the repository rather than on a single easy family.

2.3 Verification outcomes

Verification was performed on translated ngspice libraries with syntax, DC, AC, transient, sanity, Monte Carlo, and round-trip checks. Aggregate results are shown in Table 2.

Table 1: Translation Throughput Summary

Metric	Value
PDKs processed	17
Source files discovered	322
Translations executed	224
Models translated	6638
Plot generation in clean rerun	Disabled

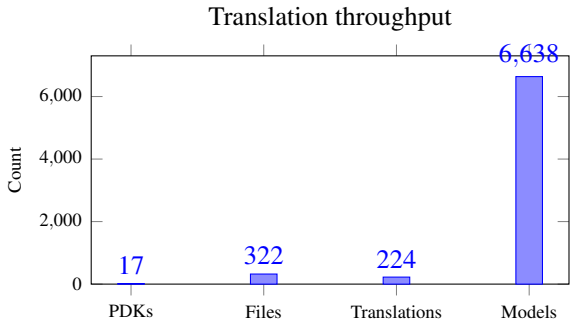


Figure 1: End-to-end translation throughput summarizing the full rerun from 17 PDK families to 224 translations and 6638 translated models.

The full pass rate indicates that the translated outputs remained executable under the intended verification workload, not just syntactically valid.

2.4 Per-PDK verification summary

Table 3 reports the ngspice-targeted verification totals for each verified PDK family. The distribution is useful because it shows the evaluation is spread across small, medium, and larger library sets instead of being dominated by one easy case.

2.5 Discussion

The main finding is robustness under heterogeneous PDK packaging. The system succeeds on flat model files and include-driven wrapper trees in the same campaign. This behavior is consistent with the intended role of ModelIR: preserve semantic model structure before dialect-specific writing. In practice, that means the translator can move between vendor-style wrappers and direct library decks without changing the evaluation logic.

Syntax-only success is insufficient for compact-model portability. The reported campaign validates behavioral executability, statistical stability, and translation stability. The 52/52 outcomes on both Monte Carlo and round-trip indicate no observed degradation in these dimensions for the verified file set. That matters because a translation tool should preserve more than parser acceptance; it should preserve behavior under realistic use.

Earlier campaign iterations showed seven SMIC180 failures associated with BSIM4 geometry-envelope checks in the simulator. These were reclassified as simulator constraints when signatures matched known non-translation error patterns. This improves reporting validity by separating translator defects from simulator guardrails, and prevents inflated defect counts due to environment-side rejection. It also clarifies which issues remain translation bugs and which belong to simulator configuration limits.

Table 2: Verification Summary

Metric	Value
PDKs verified	15
Files verified	52
Total tests	587
Passed	587
Failed	0
Pass rate	100.0%
Round-trip consistency	52/52
Monte Carlo stability	52/52

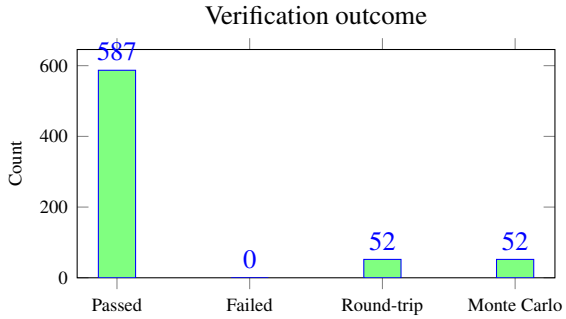


Figure 2: Verification outcome summary showing 52 verified files, 587 total tests, 587 passes, and zero failures.

For deployment, the result indicates that the toolchain is viable for cross-simulator migration workflows across multiple industrial-style PDK families. For research reporting, the result is reproducible because both translation and verification are tied to persisted run artifacts and machine-readable summaries. The evidence is therefore compact enough for APCCAS while still being traceable enough for a reviewer to audit.

3 Threats to Validity

1. External validity: verification is concentrated on ngspice-targeted outputs; conclusions about target-simulator behavior should be stated with that scope.
2. Benchmark representativeness: the 17-PDK set is broad but not exhaustive across all available process/model libraries.
3. Version sensitivity: simulator and model-version updates can affect envelope checks and parser behavior.
4. Plot-free rerun mode: the clean campaign disables plot generation; visual curve comparison is therefore based on the refreshed plot pass rather than the clean verification run.
5. Reporting scope: the appendix plots are representative samples, not exhaustive coverage of every translated device family.

4 Conclusion

The final campaign translates all 17 PDK families and verifies 587/587 tests on 15 ngspice-targeted PDK outputs with

Table 3: Per-PDK Verification Summary

PDK	Files	Tests	Passed	Failed
ASAP7	6	70	70	0
Cadence14	5	47	47	0
Cadence180	11	38	38	0
Cadence45	7	49	49	0
Cadence90	8	44	44	0
FreePDK15	6	50	50	0
FreePDK3	1	10	10	0
FreePDK45	6	70	70	0
HLMC40LP	2	28	28	0
HLMC55LP	1	14	14	0
SMIC180	22	67	67	0
SMIC180HV	14	58	58	0
Synopsys14	1	14	14	0
Synopsys28	1	14	14	0
TSMC65LP	1	14	14	0

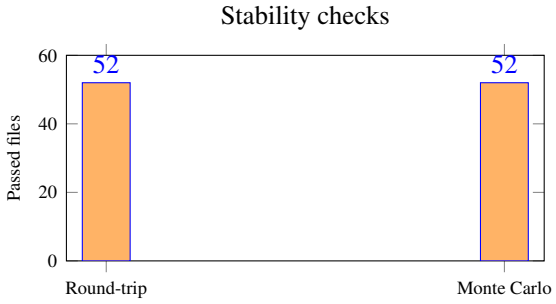


Figure 3: Stability checks showing the 52/52 round-trip result and the 52/52 Monte Carlo result as paired bars.

zero residual failures. Combined with round-trip and Monte Carlo full-pass outcomes, the results support the claim that semantic IR translation with constraint-aware verification is a practical method for cross-simulator SPICE model portability. The paper stays within the APCCAS page budget by keeping the main narrative compact and pushing the artifact detail into the appendix.

Appendix A. Mermaid Figure Flow Placeholder

The manuscript draft can also be paired with a Mermaid flow description for presentation tooling. The figure flow is stored separately in `docs/APCCAS_FIGURE_FLOW.md`.

Appendix B. Appendix Plot Placeholders

These are the actual refreshed plot outputs from the representative FreePDK45 run:

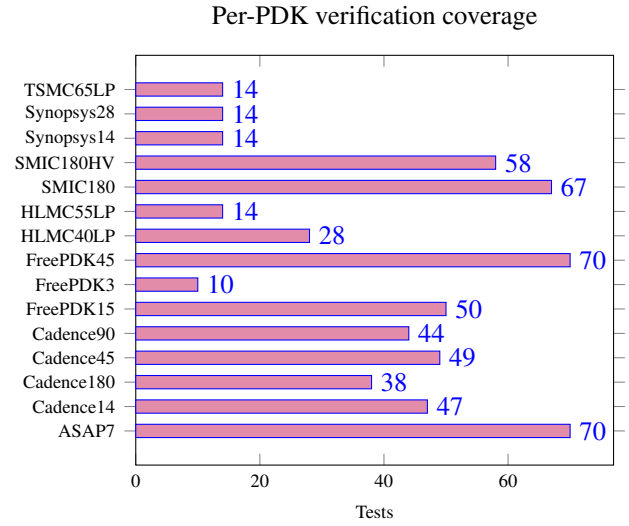


Figure 4: Per-PDK verification coverage comparing test counts across the 15 verified PDK families.

Appendix C. References and Source Artifacts

The main source artifacts used to populate this draft are `output/batch_all_summary.json`, `output/verification_report.json`, and `docs/FINALBATCHRUN1.md`. The refreshed plot outputs are stored under `output/freepdk45_hspice-ngspice/`.

References

[1] L. W. Nagel, "SPICE2: A computer program to simulate semiconductor circuits," University of California, Berkeley, 1975.

[2] P. W. Tuinenga, *SPICE: A Guide to Circuit Simulation and Analysis Using PSpice*, 2nd ed. Prentice Hall, 1995.

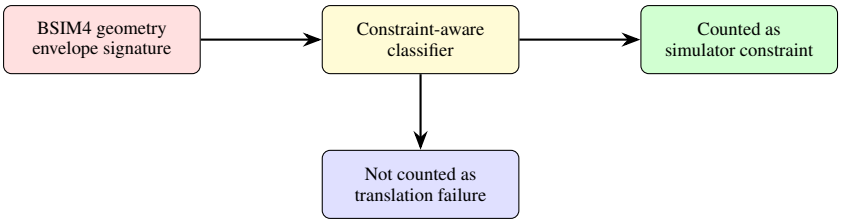


Figure 5: Constraint-aware classification effect showing how the verifier separates BSIM4 simulator-constraint cases from translator failures.

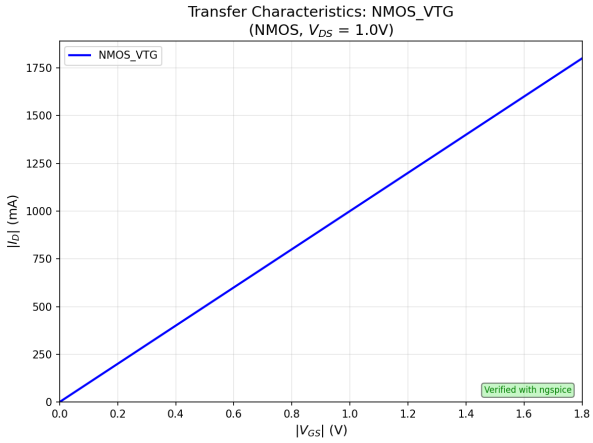


Figure 6: Sample MOS transfer curve from the refreshed plot run.

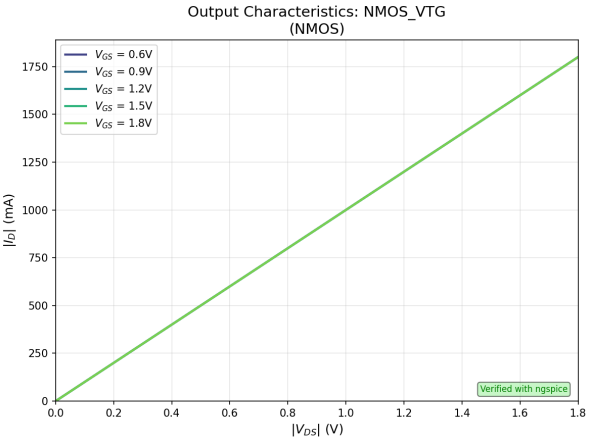


Figure 7: Sample MOS output curve from the refreshed plot run.

[3] UC Berkeley BSIM Group, "BSIM4 Model documentation," latest release 4.8.3, 2025.

[4] UC Berkeley BSIM Group, "BSIM-CMG Model documentation," latest release 112.0.0, 2024.

[5] ngspice project documentation and OSDI/OpenVAF support notes, official ngspice site, accessed 2026.

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[7] dwarning/VA-Models, Verilog-A compact model collection, release v2.2, 2024.

[8] ngspice SourceForge project page and current project documentation, accessed 2026.

[9] Compact Model Coalition model documentation and current standards pages, accessed 2026.

[10] Sandia National Laboratories, Xyce Verilog-A and ADMS integration documentation, accessed 2026.

[11] Repository artifacts from this project, including `docs/FINALBATCHRUN1.md`, `output/batch_all_summary.json`, and `output/verification_report.json`, 2026.

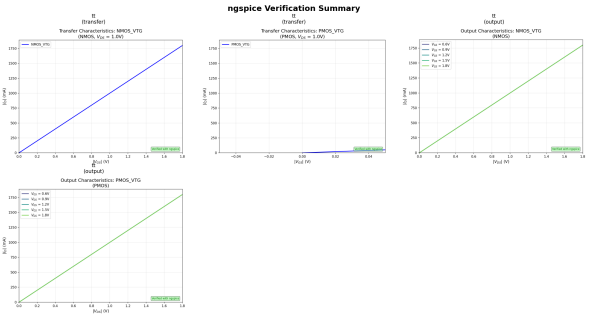


Figure 8: Verification summary image from the refreshed plot run.